

VIFM ASSESSMENT SERVICES

Competency-Based Interview (CBI)

A structured, two-hour behavioural interview built on the VIFM Competency Framework, with an interview guide and a report for every candidate.

Our approach, the interview guide, and a sample report | October 2026

Past behaviour, asked the same way of every candidate

A structured series of questions that asks the candidate for specific examples of what they actually did, probed systematically and rated against defined behavioural indicators.

Why structure matters

Predicts job performance

Structured interviews predict performance roughly twice as well as unstructured ones (operational validity about .51 against .38, Schmidt and Hunter, 1998).

Fair by design

Every candidate for the role is asked the same questions. Only the probes vary with the answers.

Evidence, not impressions

The interviewer records what the candidate did, then classifies the evidence against positive and negative indicators.

A defined scale

Each competency is rated 1 to 5 against anchors written for that competency, with a 'no evidence' option so a thin answer is never a 1.

Built on the VIFM Competency Framework



4

Domains

Thinking · Results · People · Self



8

Clusters

Group related competencies



21

Competencies

Each with a definition and positive and negative indicators



1 to 5

Anchored scale

Behaviourally anchored ratings for every competency

The same framework drives Persona (self-report), Reflect 360, Pre-Hire and the VIFM Assessment Centre, so interview ratings can be read next to every other VIFM signal.



Thinking domain

How the person analyses, decides and sets direction

STRATEGIC & COMMERCIAL REASONING

Critical Analysis & Judgement

Breaks ambiguous, data-heavy problems into their parts, tests assumptions, and turns the reasoning into timely, balanced decisions.

STRATEGIC & COMMERCIAL REASONING

Strategic & Commercial Insight

Reads the competitive, economic and regulatory landscape and converts that insight into a clear, prioritised direction framed around long-term value.

INNOVATION & COMPLEXITY

Creative Problem-Solving

Generates and tests original approaches that improve products, processes or outcomes instead of defaulting to precedent.

INNOVATION & COMPLEXITY

Navigating Complexity & Ambiguity

Makes sense of high-volume, interdependent and conflicting information, and stays decisive when direction, data or conditions are unclear.



Results domain

How the person gets things done and serves those who depend on the work

DELIVERY & EXECUTION

Proactive Initiative

Moves on opportunities and tough challenges early and with energy, rather than waiting to be directed.

DELIVERY & EXECUTION

Delivery & Accountability

Takes personal responsibility for measurable results and follows through from commitment to completion, owning mistakes openly.

DELIVERY & EXECUTION

Planning & Resourcing

Sequences work so the most important commitments are met, and secures and deploys the people, budget and tools the work needs.

DELIVERY & EXECUTION

Process Optimisation

Designs and improves workflows for efficiency and control, removing waste without sacrificing compliance or quality.

CUSTOMER & STAKEHOLDER FOCUS

Customer & Stakeholder Focus

Understands and anticipates the needs of customers and stakeholders, internal and external, and delivers reliably against them.



People domain

How the person communicates, influences and grows others

INFLUENCE & COMMUNICATION

Clear & Adaptive Communication

Conveys complex content clearly, tailoring message, tone and medium to the audience, and listens to check understanding.

INFLUENCE & COMMUNICATION

Influence & Agreement

Builds well-reasoned, audience-aware cases that win genuine commitment, and resolves disagreement directly and calmly.

INFLUENCE & COMMUNICATION

Networks & Collaboration

Builds and sustains useful relationships inside and outside the organisation, investing in them before they are needed.

LEADING & DEVELOPING OTHERS

Coaching & Talent Growth

Actively develops others toward both their own potential and the organisation's future needs.

LEADING & DEVELOPING OTHERS

Building Cohesive Teams

Forms teams with a shared identity and purpose that combine diverse strengths to deliver together.

LEADING & DEVELOPING OTHERS

Mobilising Around Purpose

Articulates a compelling sense of direction that connects people's work to a larger goal and motivates action.

Self domain



How the person manages themselves, their standards and their growth

GROWTH & PERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

Resilience & Composure

Stays calm, clear and constructive under pressure, scrutiny and setbacks, and recovers quickly from disappointment.

GROWTH & PERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

Learning Agility

Learns rapidly from new and first-time situations and applies the lessons in unfamiliar conditions.

INTEGRITY & CHARACTER

Integrity & Principled Courage

Acts honestly and fairly, within the spirit as well as the letter of professional standards, and challenges poor decisions.

INTEGRITY & CHARACTER

Self-Insight

Uses feedback and honest reflection to understand own strengths, limits, and impact on others.

INTEGRITY & CHARACTER

Emotional Regulation & Empathy

Recognises and manages own emotions and reads others' accurately, responding in ways that fit the situation.

INTEGRITY & CHARACTER

Cultural & Inclusive Sensitivity

Understands and respects diverse norms and perspectives, and works inclusively across them.

From role to interview guide in four steps



The two-hour interview

10 min**Opening**

Welcome, purpose, the competencies to be covered, note-taking explained, consent confirmed.

10 min**Career overview**

A short walk through recent roles to settle the candidate and surface examples to return to.

90 min**Six competencies, about fifteen minutes each**

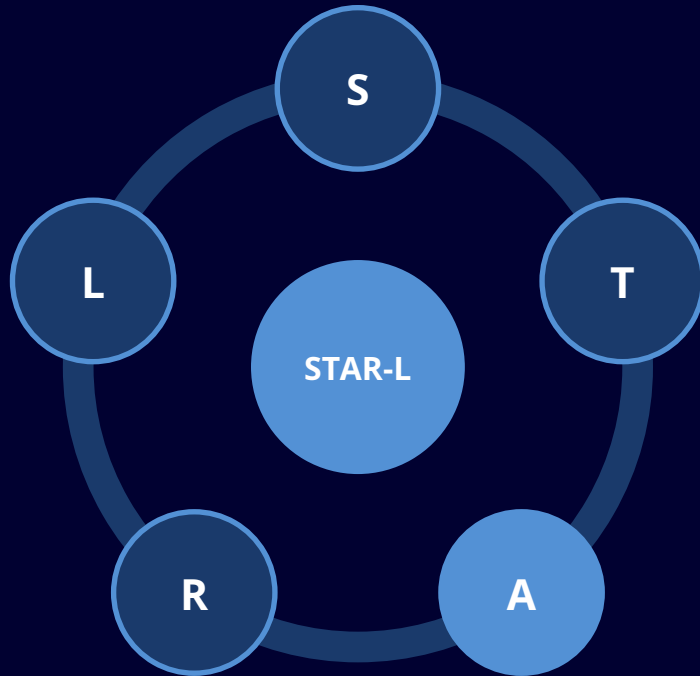
Same questions for every candidate. Probes follow the answer. Evidence recorded, never evaluated in the room.

10 min**Close**

Anything to add, the candidate's questions, next steps and timing.

Two interviewers where the decision is a selection decision: one leads and probes, one records. For development interviews one trained interviewer is sufficient.

STAR-L: how every question is asked



S

Situation

What was the context? When, where, who was involved?

T

Task

What were you responsible for? What had to be achieved?

A

Action

What did you, personally, do? The interviewer spends most of the time here.

R

Result

What happened? How do you know? What did it cost or deliver?

L

Learning

What would you do differently? What did you carry forward?

Answers in the hypothetical or the plural ("we would", "the team usually") are redirected to a specific, personal example.

THE INTERVIEW GUIDE

One page per competency

Printed or on screen, the same for every candidate

WHAT IS ON THE PAGE



Definition

The competency as the framework defines it, with why it matters for this role.



Indicators

What positive and negative evidence looks like, so notes can be classified.



Three questions, three probes each

Asked in order; probes follow the answer.



Notes

Space to record what the candidate said and did, factually.



Rating

1 to 5 against the anchors for this competency, or NE for no evidence.

Sample: Critical Analysis & Judgement

DEFINITION

Breaks ambiguous, data-heavy problems into their parts, tests assumptions, and weighs competing explanations before reaching a view. Turns that reasoning into timely, balanced decisions, even when information is incomplete, weighing risk, stakeholders and second-order consequences.

POSITIVE INDICATORS

- Judges the relevance and importance of different pieces of information accurately
- Identifies underlying relationships, causes and effects
- Identifies potential weaknesses in proposals or plans

NEGATIVE INDICATORS

- Draws conclusions without sufficient evidence
- Fails to identify inconsistencies in data or arguments

QUESTION 1 OF 3

Tell me about a time the numbers you were given did not add up, and you had to get to the bottom of it.

Probe What first made you doubt the figures?

Probe How did you separate the cause from the symptoms?

Probe What did you decide, and what happened as a result?

Notes

INTERVIEW RATING

1

2

3

4

5

NE

Anchor for 4: Quickly distinguishes critical from peripheral information, uncovers hidden problems, and weighs multiple competing explanations before deciding.

One scale, anchored for every competency

- | | | |
|----|---------------------------|---|
| 5 | Role model | Consistently exceeds the role requirement; several strong, specific examples with clear personal ownership. |
| 4 | Above requirement | Above requirement in most situations; clear positive evidence with few gaps. |
| 3 | Meets requirement | Adequate; meets the role requirement, evidence may be uneven across the indicators. |
| 2 | Development needed | Below requirement; limited or mixed evidence, some negative indicators present. |
| 1 | Significant gap | Little or no positive evidence; negative indicators dominate the examples given. |
| NE | No evidence | The interview produced no usable evidence for this competency. Never rated as a 1. |

Generic labels are not enough. Every competency carries its own written anchor for each point, so two interviewers read a 3 the same way.

After the interview: from notes to a rating



Write up the same day

Notes are completed while the evidence is fresh, before any rating.



Classify the evidence

Each piece of evidence is matched to a positive or negative indicator of one competency.



Rate against the anchors

The rating is the anchor the evidence best fits, not an average of impressions.



Calibrate

Where there are two interviewers, ratings are agreed in a short discussion with the evidence on the table.



Report

A per-competency report with the evidence, the rating against the role target, strengths and development areas.



Feed back

The candidate receives a summary of strengths and development areas, whatever the decision.

The CBI report

01

Summary

The six competencies with their rating against the role's target level on one page, with an indicative overall read and the headline strengths and development areas.

02

Evidence per competency

For each competency: the rating and its anchor, a summary of what the candidate described, the indicators observed and the gaps, and the interviewers' confidence in the evidence.

03

Development and decision

Suggested development actions drawn from the framework, a decision-integration box the panel completes, and a plain statement of what the interview can and cannot tell you.

Every VIFM report states on its face what it is: interview evidence about past behaviour, to be read alongside other evidence. It is never a hiring decision on its own.

Fair to candidates, defensible to the organisation



Standardised

Same competencies, same questions, same scale for every candidate for the role. Deviations are recorded.



Evidence-based

Ratings cite the behaviour described. No rating without notes; no evidence means NE, not a low score.



Trained interviewers

Interviewers are briefed on the guide, the method, note-taking and common rating errors before they interview.



Monitored

Outcomes can be monitored by group for adverse impact, and the interview record supports any later review or appeal.

Structured interview validity: Schmidt and Hunter (1998), Psychological Bulletin 124(2); McDaniel, Whetzel, Schmidt and Maurer (1994), Journal of Applied Psychology 79(4).

On its own, or as part of a fuller picture

Interview only

A CBI on the role's competencies, with the guide and the report. Right for shortlists where the organisation wants structure and evidence quickly.

- ✓ Interview guide per role
- ✓ Trained interviewers
- ✓ Report per candidate

Interview plus VIFM instruments

Add Persona (behavioural self-report on the same framework) and Logica (reasoning) before the interview, so the guide can target what the self-report flags.

- ✓ Self-report read next to interview evidence
- ✓ Reasoning as a separate signal
- ✓ Combined report

Assessment centre

The CBI becomes one exercise in a VIFM Assessment Centre with simulations and trained assessors, integrated in a wash-up to one rating per competency.

- ✓ Multiple exercises per competency
- ✓ Assessor consensus
- ✓ Full centre report

NEXT STEPS

Ready to run for your first role

- ✓ Agree the role profile and the five to seven competencies
- ✓ VIFM generates the interview guide and briefs the interviewers
- ✓ Run the interviews; VIFM scores and calibrates
- ✓ Reports delivered within five working days of the last interview